

Enhancing Manitoba's Innovation Ecosystem: A Competitive Analysis and Strategic Roadmap for MINT

1.0 Introduction: Context and Strategic Imperative

This report provides a comparative analysis of Manitoba's Innovation and New Technology (MINT) initiative against peer provinces. As a one-year-old entity, MINT has successfully established a strong foundation by consolidating technology functions and driving the modernization of public services. In a competitive national landscape, the ability to demonstrate tangible innovation outcomes is paramount to attracting investment and talent. This analysis serves as a constructive, forward-looking roadmap for continuous improvement. By examining the strategies and reporting frameworks of leading jurisdictions like British Columbia, Alberta, and Ontario, this report identifies key opportunities for Manitoba to enhance its support for private-sector commercialization and digital innovation.

To chart this path forward, it is essential to first acknowledge the significant foundational achievements MINT has accomplished in its inaugural year.

2.0 MINT's Foundational Achievements in its Inaugural Year

In its first year, MINT strategically prioritized the modernization of the public sector. This focus represents essential groundwork, building a resilient and efficient digital government that serves as a prerequisite for fostering innovation across the broader economy. These foundational efforts have established a modern platform from which to launch more ambitious, ecosystem-wide initiatives.

The 2024-25 MINT Annual Report highlights several key accomplishments that form this solid base:

- **Digital Modernization of Public Services:** MINT successfully launched several citizen-facing digital services designed to improve access, speed, and reliability. Key launches include the new online Health Card application system, a streamlined Temporary Work Permit extension system, a public Teacher's Registry to enhance transparency, and an upgraded Traffic Management System with real-time capabilities.
- **Strengthening Core Technology Infrastructure:** Significant progress was made in upgrading the government's internal technology stack. This includes the modernization of internal collaboration tools to improve staff productivity, upgrades to

the network backbone to enhance performance, and enhancements to core enterprise systems for functions like contract and learning management.

- **Enhancing Cybersecurity Resilience:** A standalone Cyber Security Division was established within MINT to centralize oversight and strategy. The division completed a comprehensive security inventory and risk assessment, laying the groundwork for an improved, long-term security posture that builds public trust in digital services.
- **Establishing a Strategic Mandate:** The creation of MINT as a consolidated department marks a significant structural improvement. Its integrated structure, combining internal modernization with external innovation policy, represents a unique competitive advantage, reducing silos and providing clearer ownership of the province's entire digital and innovation agenda under a unified vision and five core objectives.

These achievements represent a robust starting point for MINT. The following comparative analysis builds upon this foundation to identify strategic opportunities for future growth and competitive positioning.

3.0 Comparative Analysis: Provincial Approaches to Innovation Reporting and Strategy

Comparing provincial reporting frameworks is a powerful tool for strategic planning. The objective is not to directly contrast nascent metrics but to evaluate the strategic focus and maturity of different innovation ecosystems. How a province measures and reports on innovation reveals its core priorities, whether they are centered on internal government efficiency, direct support for businesses, or long-term economic diversification.

The following table synthesizes the distinct approaches taken by Manitoba, British Columbia, Alberta, and Ontario, highlighting a key divergence between MINT's current focus on public-sector modernization and its peers' emphasis on external, business-facing outcomes.

Table 1: Comparison of Provincial Innovation Reporting Focus

Feature	Manitoba (MINT)	British Columbia (Innovate BC)	Alberta & Ontario
Primary Focus	Internal public service and digital modernization. Reporting centers on operational improvements and new government service launches.	Program- and outcome-oriented. Reporting focuses on the impact of direct business support programs and ecosystem engagement.	A clear commercialization continuum from idea to market success (Alberta) and a dual focus on public service performance and ecosystem impact (Ontario).

Key Reported Metrics	Narrative descriptions of digital service launches (e.g., new Health Card system) and internal infrastructure upgrades.	Quantified outcomes, such as the number of companies supported (309 in the CRM program), participants in IP programs (129), and qualitative skill improvements.	Hard metrics on investment attracted, revenue growth, and jobs created (Alberta). User adoption statistics and service efficiency metrics for digital services (Ontario).
Ecosystem Engagement	Indirect support through partnerships (e.g., Research Manitoba). Business-facing programs are less prominent in annual reporting.	Direct engagement through highly visible, business-facing programs like <i>Fast Pilot</i> , accelerator networks, and an IP Hub for entrepreneurs.	An end-to-end support model using accelerators and commercialization networks (Alberta) and deep ecosystem hubs like MaRS Discovery District (Ontario).
Strategic Visibility	AI and data strategy are embedded within MINT's broader objectives, but are not presented as a distinct public "playbook."	Strategy is communicated through the outcomes and branding of specific business-facing programs rather than a single, overarching public roadmap.	A public-facing, named digital and data strategy ("Building a Digital Ontario") that signals clear priorities to partners and the public.

This analysis reveals a fundamental divergence in strategic posture: while MINT reports on the *foundations* of digital government, its peers report on the *economic outcomes* of innovation.

4.0 Strategic Opportunities for MINT to Enhance Competitiveness

The insights gained from the comparative analysis should not be viewed as shortcomings but as strategic opportunities for MINT to build upon its strong foundation. By adopting proven practices from peer provinces, Manitoba can accelerate its innovation impact, enhance transparency, and gain a competitive edge. MINT's integrated structure provides a unique platform to implement these changes more effectively than its siloed peers. The following actions represent the most promising pathways to achieving this.

1. **Shift from Activity Reporting to Impact Measurement:** To elevate its strategic value, MINT must shift its reporting focus from describing activities (e.g., "launched a new system") to measuring ecosystem-wide impact. This requires adopting quantified, business-focused metrics such as the number of companies supported (**309 in BC's CRM program**), IP program participants (**129 in BC**), and hard economic outcomes like private investment leveraged, revenue growth, and jobs created, as reported by **Alberta Innovates**. This approach provides tangible proof of economic return on investment and strengthens the case for continued support.
2. **Establish a Branded Business-Facing Program Suite:** While MINT's integrated structure is a strength, its business-facing programs are less visible than those of its peers. Manitoba should create a clearly branded suite of innovation and commercialization programs, similar to **Innovate BC's** well-defined **Fast Pilot** program. Delineating and naming these offerings (e.g., for AI adoption, pilot funding, or productivity grants) would clarify the value proposition for startups and scale-ups, making it easier for them to identify and access the support they need to grow.
3. **Strengthen Direct Commercialization and IP Support:** To bridge the gap between research and market success, MINT can incorporate more direct and flexible support for commercialization. Adopting a flexible funding model like **Alberta's Voucher Program** would allow SMEs to rapidly access funds for prototyping and product development. Furthermore, embedding intellectual property strategy services, inspired by **BC's IP Hub**, would equip Manitoba's innovators with the tools needed to protect and monetize their creations, ensuring long-term value remains within the province.
4. **Publish a Public-Facing Digital and Innovation Roadmap:** Transparency and strategic clarity are powerful tools for attracting partners and investment. Manitoba should develop and publish a concise, public-facing AI and Data Strategy, inspired by the "Building a Digital Ontario" roadmap. Such a document would articulate clear principles for responsible AI, outline a plan for provincial data infrastructure, and signal Manitoba's strategic priorities to the national innovation community, positioning MINT as a forward-thinking leader in digital governance.

Implementing these strategic opportunities requires a systematic approach, which can be achieved through a dedicated internal framework for continuous improvement.

5.0 Implementing a Framework for Continuous Improvement

To execute the strategies outlined above effectively, MINT requires a structured internal framework. This mechanism is not about creating bureaucracy, but about embedding a consistent, data-informed, and agile approach to program management and policy development. This framework is the operational engine that will enable MINT to successfully measure ecosystem impact, launch clearly defined business-facing programs, strengthen commercialization support, and develop policy with evidence-based clarity. An *Innovation and Problem-Solving Framework* would ensure that funding decisions and program enhancements are aligned with strategic goals and responsive to the evolving needs of Manitoba's economy.

The core components of this proposed framework would include:

- **Structured Application Assessment:** Implement standardized criteria to evaluate funding applications based on innovation potential, market viability, and alignment with Manitoba's economic objectives. This approach supports professional judgment with a transparent, consistent methodology, ensuring the highest-potential projects receive support.
- **Systematic Program Improvement Loop:** Create a formal process for systematically logging and analyzing program delivery challenges, whether they are bottlenecks, unclear criteria, or stakeholder complaints. This data, combined with structured feedback from surveys and consultations, would be used to continuously refine and improve program efficiency and client experience.
- **Evidence-Based Policy Development:** Establish a practice of regularly analyzing market trends, competitor programs in other provinces, and evolving sector conditions. This external intelligence will allow MINT to identify gaps in its support offerings and inform policy revisions, ensuring its programs remain relevant, competitive, and impactful.

By adopting this framework, MINT can embed a culture of continuous improvement, ensuring its programs and policies evolve dynamically to meet the needs of Manitoba's growing innovation ecosystem.

6.0 Conclusion: Positioning Manitoba as an Integrated Innovation Leader

Manitoba's Innovation and New Technology (MINT) initiative has made impressive foundational progress in its first year, successfully modernizing core government systems and digital services. To build on this momentum and enhance its competitive standing, the path forward is clear. By integrating ecosystem-wide impact metrics, strengthening direct commercialization pathways, and adopting a structured framework for continuous improvement, MINT can fully leverage its unique, integrated structure. This strategic evolution will not only demonstrate greater value to citizens and businesses but also solidify Manitoba's position as a national leader that uniquely integrates efficient digital government with robust, private-sector economic innovation.

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